2.2.5 Information Manipulation

Information is a crucial resource that states provide to IOs, and populists can wield it effectively to undermine them. The WHO, for instance, requires comprehensive data on disease outbreaks in order to coordinate global responses (Ge 2022). Similarly, the International Monetary Fund relies on state-provided economic data to forecast systemic risks, while the International Atomic Energy Agency depends on insights into nuclear programs to enforce nonproliferation agreements. The absence of reliable information can cripple global efforts to address trade flows, human-rights violations, health crises, and nuclear compliance, diminishing IOs' ability to deliver on their missions (Carnegie and Carson 2020).

Although IOs employ tools like surveillance technologies, open-source data, and on-the-ground inspections to collect information, their capabilities are often constrained. The IAEA sends inspectors to nuclear sites, and the European Commission monitors elections for fairness (Kelley 2009), but such efforts rarely cover the full spectrum of data needed. Member states frequently resist empowering IOs with greater independent capacity, fearing a loss of sovereignty or an expansion of IO authority into unintended areas (Barnett and Finnemore 1999). States may allow election monitors to be present only at specific polling stations—for example, while pursuing subversion elsewhere (Kelley 2012). As a result, IOs are typically left dependent on the willingness of member states to share critical information.

This dependence gives populists a unique opportunity to undermine IOs. Populist leaders may deliberately withhold data, provide false or incomplete information, or weaken domestic mechanisms for data collection (Giacalone and Knouse 1990; Serenko 2019). For example, if a state halts the publication of economic statistics or dismisses independent experts, the quality of information flowing to IOs deteriorates. By eroding the information pipeline, populists can hobble IOs' ability to function effectively.

Populists can further distort IO-generated data to fit their narratives, selectively presenting findings or simplifying complex issues for political gain (Ebrahim 2002). They often challenge the expertise and authority of the professionals who inform IO decisions, framing them as out-of-touch